

How to Create the .env.example File

A **.env.example** file is a template. It contains all the variable names your project needs, but leaves the sensitive values (like passwords and custom hosts) blank or filled with placeholder instructions.

1. In the **same folder** as your server.js file, create a new file named exactly **.env.example**.
2. Paste the following text into it and save:

```
# Server Configuration
PORT=3000

# Database Configuration
# For the host, use '127.0.0.1' if you are the host, or the ngrok
address provided by the host.
DB_HOST=your_database_host_here

# Use 'root' if you are the host, or the custom team username
provided by the host.
DB_USER=your_database_username_here

# Leave blank if you are the host using default XAMPP/WAMP
settings.
DB_PASSWORD=your_database_password_here

DB_NAME=careerConnect_db

# Use '3306' if you are the host, or the custom ngrok port number
provided by the host.
DB_PORT=your_database_port_here
```

When your teammates pull your code from GitHub, they will see this file. They just need to duplicate it, rename the copy to **.env**, and fill in the values you give them!

Clarification on phpMyAdmin & Team Access

To clear up your last question: **No, your teammates do not need to create the project_tam user in phpMyAdmin, and they do not need to look at phpMyAdmin on their own computers.**

Here is how it actually works:

- **Your computer is the central server:** Because you are hosting the database via ngrok, **everything lives entirely on your machine.**
- **They connect through the code:** When your teammates run your Node.js application, their code reaches out over the internet, through ngrok, directly into *your* local database.
- **They don't have a local copy:** They don't need to open XAMPP, WAMP, or phpMyAdmin on their laptops at all to use the application. If they open phpMyAdmin on *their* computers, they will just be looking at their own empty local standalone environment, not your shared project data.

What if they **DO** want to visually look at the database?

If your teammates want to see the tables and data visually (like you do in phpMyAdmin), they can use a free database desktop client like **DBeaver** or **HeidiSQL**.

Inside that software, they can plug in your ngrok credentials (4.tcp.ngrok.io, project_tam, your password, and port 24494), and they will be able to view and edit your database tables in real-time from their homes!

You are fully configured and ready to go! To finalize your setup, would you like me to show you:

- How your teammates can connect using **DBeaver** to view the database tables?
- How to update your code to handle **Express port changes** using the environment file?